

Still Pinned, Never Adjourned

A Quasi-Experiment on Whether Naming an End Date Shortens a Group Chat’s Working Life

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Background

A group chat spun up for one job — a bond clean, a working bee, a house move — often keeps running long after the job closes. Does naming an end date up front actually shorten a chat’s working life, or does it just get pinned and ignored?

Aims

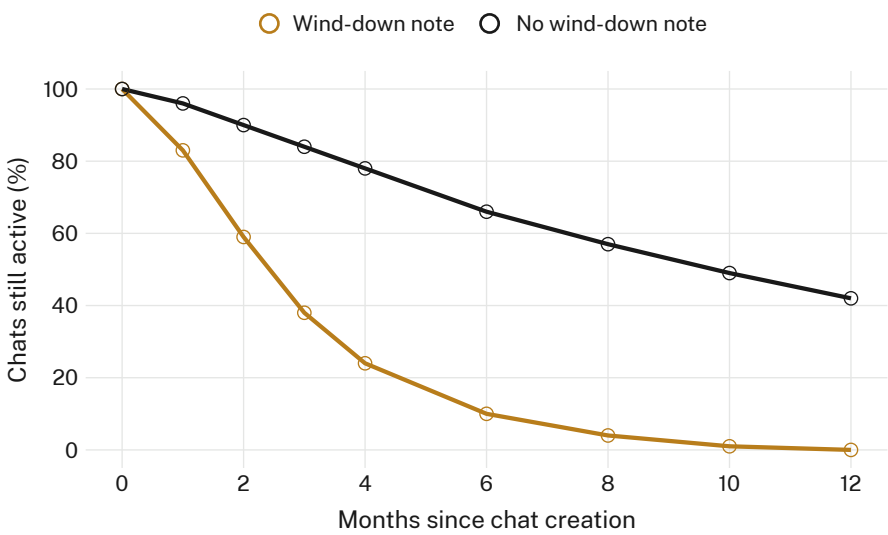
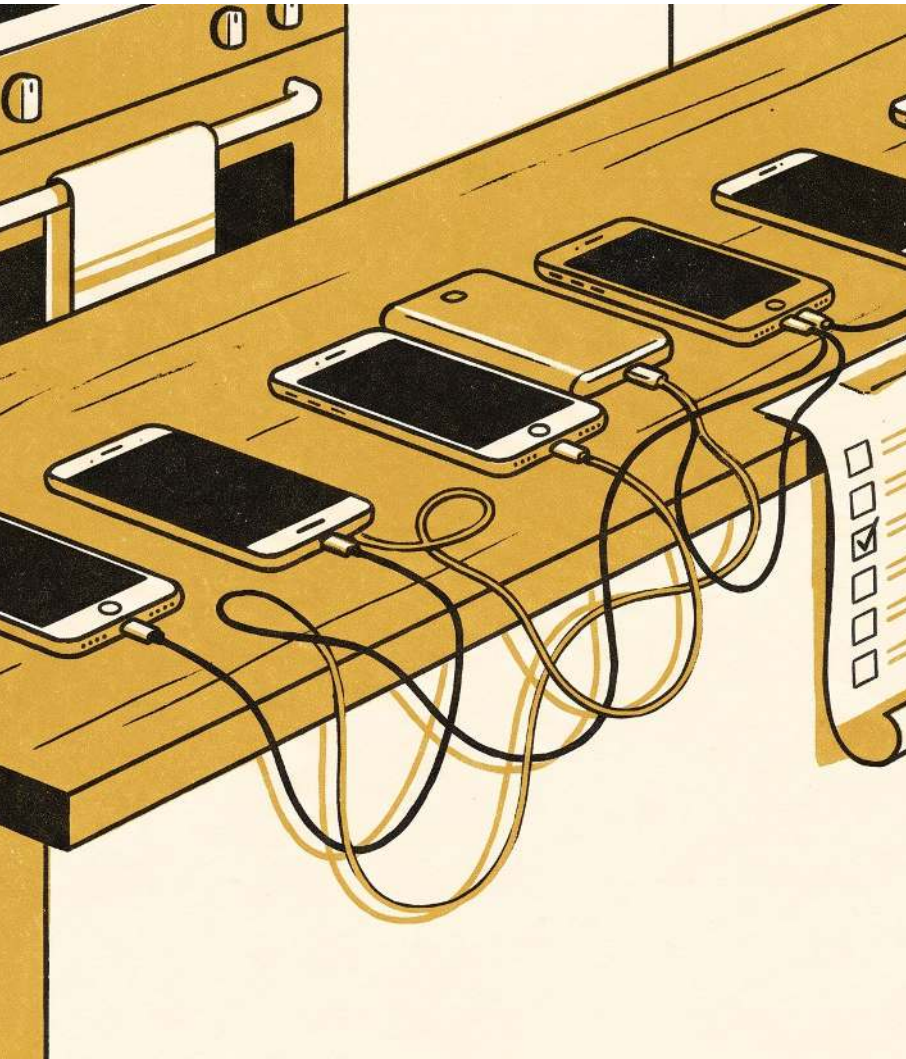
- Test whether a self-authored wind-down note shortens time to functional silence
- Compare off-purpose house-rule decisions in chats with and without one
- Characterise what fills a chat once its founding task closes

Methods

- n = 64 share-house group chats (bond clean, move-in, working bee) · message audit monthly to month 4, then bimonthly · 14-month window
- Grouping by presence/absence of a self-authored wind-down note at creation (naturally occurring, not assigned): 29 with, 35 without
- Messages coded on-purpose / off-purpose house-rule / social; blind coding scheme held constant across groups

Results

Chats without a wind-down note took roughly four times as long to reach functional silence as those that named one (Mann-Whitney U, $p < .01$), and kept generating house-rule decisions the founding task never covered (0.6 vs 4.1 per chat, post-closure).



Median time to functional silence (30 days with no messages): 2.4 months with a wind-down note (n = 29) versus 9.8 months without (n = 35), tracked March 2025–May 2026.

Discussion & conclusions

A stated end date reads less as information than as permission to stop checking. Off-purpose decisions cluster in months three to six, once the founding task is long settled, and rarely concern anything the chat was named for — shoe policy, quiet hours, and bin-roster edits accounted for most of them. The wind-down note appears to function less as a deadline than as a licence to mute: once the note has been read, whoever is left in the chat stops treating a reply as required, and the thread drifts from coordination into ambient house governance nobody formally convened. Chats without a note showed no equivalent permission structure, so the same drift happened more slowly and less legibly, one favour and one grievance at a time. Next: whether naming a successor channel for ongoing house business closes the gap further, or simply relocates the same drift under a new name.

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Messages coded from participant-submitted screenshots only; no thread content retained beyond the coding window.